



Fall Semester, 2025

OCTOBER 27: UPDATED THE SYLLABUS REGARDING THE OCTOBER 28 CLASS! (WE'LL MEET.)

INTRODUCTION TO SOCIOLOGY FOR ENGINEERING AND ECONOMICS STUDENTS

(“Late Capitalism and its Military-Industrial Complex”)

Lecturer: Zoltán LAKATOS, PhD

Schedule: Tuesday, 16:15-17:45; Room: E306ab

Code: BMEGT43A002

Credits: 2

Units per week: 2

Assessment: non-standardized test (end-of-term)

Office hours: Tuesday, 18:30-20:30 (appointment by email)

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MS Teams code: look it up at the Moodle site

Students are required to sign up at the course's Moodle site: <https://edu.gtk.bme.hu/course/view.php?id=9362>

This site is used for storing electronic versions of the readings (part of which are also available at the BME Library) and test results.

Should you find any inconsistency with the online version of the syllabus, this "hard copy" — handed out to students and available at the above Moodle link — takes precedence.

Description

Weighing the merits of a generic introductory class against the benefits of a more focused eye-opener, I have opted for the latter. This course is an initiation to sociology via two case studies.

The first is the global financial crisis of 2008 whose aftermath affects the world economy to this day. You are already familiar with some of the outcomes of this crisis; by exploring the connections between its triggers and our daily lives you will learn some key sociological concepts as a byproduct. Further, this case study provides insights into the social context of *innovations* in technology and finance. The bulk of innovation activity in *basic* technologies is rooted in government intervention — to the point that under capitalism, the latter is not accessory but fundamental.

Preparing the ground for the second part of the semester, two classes will be devoted to the sociology of racism. What conventional wisdom perceives as races do not constitute biologically meaningful subclasses of humans, yet the fiction that they do underpins power relations globally and wherever they are an important reference. That's because different races are typically conceived of as expressions of different inherent (inborn) abilities ("talents"), physical and mental. Discriminated groups are often *racialized* — i.e., portrayed as inferior in terms of socially valuable qualities.

Toward the end of the semester, we'll be looking at how racialization and technological innovation come together in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, our second case study. In October 2023, Israel was hit by a series of terrorist attacks originating in the Gaza Strip. The Israeli military's response — still in progress as of September 2025 — has involved what the International Criminal Court alleges are war crimes. This most recent escalation is the culmination of seventy-plus years of violence, including, but not limited to ethnic cleansing, discrimination, illegal occupation of land beyond international borders, terrorist attacks. Crucially from this course's perspective, it has exposed the role of war in technological innovation and the economy: Israel's position as a global tech hub stems from its ongoing management of the conflict.

Learning about these issues will also help you develop a basic understanding of late capitalism. Sociologically relevant "stuff" like power, cultural values, symbolic goods, collective action are things that impact our lives without us being mostly aware of them. The craft of sociology is to break free of conventional wisdom by asking hard questions about these things and using the methods of rational inquiry.

Grading and course requirements

1. Attendance

You are required to attend a minimum of 8 classes (tests not included). Excused absences include medical emergencies and conference talks, with proper documentation. Should we resume the lockdown (pandemic-related or other), this involves the following:

- (a) In the case of online lectures, attendance means [1] attending the classes via the course Teams channel [2] and having your camera on. If you have privacy concerns (i.e., with granting a peek into your home), you can choose from a variety of artificial backgrounds. If your computer has capability issues (e.g., it crashes when used simultaneously for taking notes and live video), then using a cellphone as a camera might be a solution. In any case, not having the required logistics for live video participation is not an argument against the attendance requirement. (A steady minority of students find the latter to be too demanding even in for in-person classes.)
- (b) I take attendance checks three times during each class: beginning (take-off), end (landing), and somewhere in-between (in-flight). This means saving screenshots of the class Teams channel in the "large gallery" mode (in which all present with their video appear on the screen). The timing of the in-flight check is never announced — the rationale being that will only count as attendance being present via your video feed at all three successive checks. Showing up late — i.e., after the take-off check — will be recorded as absence. An attendance record will be made available at the intranet site.

With regard to the in-flight check, breaks that are reasonable (e.g., washroom) are fine and should not qualify as absence (just like in an in-person setting). Their handling specific to the online environment combines good faith and logistics that is neither intrusive nor complex. For details, please download the template available at this link:

<https://drive.google.com/file/d/1zQuh9WBOLqn0T-LFphOS6HHTQmbF95AD/view?usp=sharing>

It is recommended that you keep a copy of this page on the device used for your Teams classes.

2. End-of-term test

The end-of-term test is a 90-minute assignment comprising a couple of essay-type questions. A D (2) or better is required to earn the credits for this course. You may make up for or retake this test at the end of the term. For non-attendance you will get a "not fulfilled" mark in your transcript.

Rules in class

Students are expected to arrive on time and not leave unless prior arrangements have been made. You are required to turn off your cell phones, beepers and other gizmos that may interfere with the class.

Readings

The readings have been selected so as to present some of the seminal texts in social science plus a couple of more recent writings connected to our case studies. Some are not sociology texts in the strict sense but nonetheless display an inquiry typical of sociological inquiries. The idea is that instead of reading about these texts in introductory textbooks, you will have a better grasp of the issues by reading them firsthand. See the weekly breakdown on the next two pages.

You are expected to do all the assigned readings. The original texts have been whittled down to manageable excerpts — app. 25 pages per class (276/11) on average. Each excerpt includes either a full article or the most accessible parts of a longer text. You should be able to handle this otherwise you will fail the course.

I will do my best to make available electronic versions at the course's Moodle site. While all these texts are in English, you may choose to read any of them in another (especially their original) language — say, Durkheim in French, etc. bearing in mind that in the test you will have to write your essay in English.

Schedule*

Notice the difference between week and class numbers (first and fourth columns, respectively).

WEEK	DATE	TOPICS AND READINGS: ALL TEXTS LISTED BELOW ARE REQUIRED
1	Sept 9	[1] Introduction: Why study sociology? Case study I. The Great Recession and The Global Financial Crisis of 2008 Harvey, David (2010) <i>The Enigma of Capital (and The Crises of Capitalism)</i> . London, Profile Books <i>1. The Disruption (1-39)</i>
2	Sept 16	Faculty sports day (no class)
3	Sept 23	[2] Case study I. continued + video material (subject to room capabilities) Harvey (ibid.) <i>Recommended documentary:</i> <i>"Inside Job" (2010) by Ferguson, Charles H. (director). Sony Pictures Classic</i> <i>A link to the movie will be sent out in email.</i>
4	Sept 30	[3] Case study I. continued + video material (subject to room capabilities) Bourdieu, Pierre (2005) <i>The Social Structures of the Economy</i> , Cambridge, UK, Polity Press. <i>Part II Principles of an Economic Anthropology (193-222)</i>
5	Oct 7	[4] Symbolic Goods: On The Origins of Commercial Branding Veblen, Thorstein (2007) <i>The Theory of the Leisure Class</i> , Oxford/New York, Oxford University Press. <i>I. Introductory (7-19)</i> <i>II. Pecuniary Emulation (20-27)</i> <i>IV. Conspicuous Consumption (49-69)</i>
6	Oct 14	[5] Social Facts Defined Durkheim, Emile (1982) <i>The Rules of Sociological Method</i> , New York, Free Press. <i>Introduction (1-2)</i> <i>Rules for The Observation of Social Facts (15-46)</i>
7	Oct 21	[6] Social Facts Defined (continued) Durkheim, Emile (1982) <i>The Rules of Sociological Method</i> , New York, Free Press. <i>Rules for The Observation of Social Facts (15-46)</i>
8	Oct 28 (updated)	[7] Growth Imperatives: Technological Innovation Ruttan, Vernon W. (2006) <i>Is War Necessary for Economic Growth? Military Procurement and Technology Development</i> , New York, Oxford University Press. <i>1. War and Economic Growth (3-19)</i> <i>8. Is War Necessary? (159-185)</i>

WEEK	DATE		TOPICS AND READINGS: ALL TEXTS LISTED BELOW ARE REQUIRED
9	Nov 4		[8] Races: Social, not Biological (1) Graves, Joseph L., and Alan H. Goodman (2021) <i>Racism, Not Race: Answers to Frequently Asked Questions</i> . Columbia University Press. <i>Introduction: What are Race, Racism, and Human Variation? (1-20)</i>
10	Nov 11	16:15-17:45	[9] Races: Social, not Biological (2) Graves, Joseph L., and Alan H. Goodman (2021) <i>Racism, Not Race: Answers to Frequently Asked Questions</i> . Columbia University Press. <i>Chapter One: How Did Race Become Biological? (21-41)</i>
		18:15-19:45	See note for Week 10 (Nov 18) on scheduling [10] Case study II. The Israeli-Palestinian Conflict Hanafi, Sari. 2009. "Spacio-Cide: Colonial Politics, Invisibility and Rezoning in Palestinian Territory." <i>Contemporary Arab Affairs</i> 2: 106–21.
11	Nov 18		No class* A make-up class will be organized on Nov. 11, 18:15-19:45 (Week 9, see above) or in an alternate time-slot selected by vote
12	Nov 25		[11] Case study II. Israel's Military-Industrial Complex Gordon, Neve. 2009. <i>The Political Economy of Israel's Homeland Security/Surveillance Industry</i> . The New Transparency. <i>Chapter Two: The Emergence of Israel's Homeland Security Industry (17-32)</i>
13	Dec 2		[12] Case study II. Israeli Academia in Geopolitical Context Wind, Maya. 2024. <i>Towers of Ivory and Steel. How Israeli Universities Deny Palestinian Freedom</i> . London, UK: Verso. <i>Introduction (10-24)</i> <i>1. Expertise of Subjugation (26-57)</i>
14	Dec 9		<u>End-of-term test</u>. Topics covered: Weeks 1 to 14 Same time slot as class.
15	Dec 17		<u>Make-up/retake test</u> You may make up for/retake the midterm test without signing up for the session. 18:15-19:45 Note that this is organized in a different a timeslot (Wednesday). Room TBA

*On the schedule:

- There will be **one blank week** (i.e., with no class) during the semester in addition to the faculty sports day in early September, the exact date of which is still unknown at the time of planning — but it will likely occur as per the above schedule. Students will be notified in due course.